



Make sure to share problems and possible solutions, and ensure that mistakes are treated as learning opportunities. Holding regular staff meetings and posting business updates on message boards are good ways to encourage open, honest communication.

“Train people well enough so they can leave; treat them well enough so they don’t want to.”

Sir Richard Branson, British business magnate

ENCOURAGING FLEXIBILITY

While the business is evolving, it is important to keep staff costs to a minimum. You need your team to be flexible, as well as productive. This may mean performing tasks outside normal roles or working unsociable hours. Employees are often willing to adapt to new demands if they feel they are being treated fairly. Remember to:

- **Talk to staff** before changing their roles or hours.
- **Show flexibility** in return, such as accommodating employees’ need to start early and finish early.
- **Listen to employees** who may know more detail about the tasks involved than you.

A—Achievable

Set goals that you can achieve. Assess whether you have enough staff and whether they have sufficient capacity to meet your goal. If your current systems cannot accommodate this, you may need to hire additional staff.

R—Realistic

Determine realistic goals. Consider whether your objective is possible in practical terms. For example, do you have adequate equipment? If not, you will have to source more equipment before you assign the task.

T—Time-based

Establish a time frame. In order to achieve your goal, your team may need training or you could need more storage space or better equipment. Take these factors into account and set realistic deadlines.

